PRACTICE SHEET
ENGLISH FOR PROFESSIONAL PURPOSES II, GLA U
Semester IV **Module 1: READING COMPREHENSION-III** **2026**

RC-II: Read the passage(s) below and answer the questions.

Passage 1

'Today I Rabindranath Tagore complete eighty years of my life .As I look back on the vast stretch of years that lie behind me and see in clear perspective the history of my early development, I am struck by the change that has taken place both in my own attitude and in the psychology of my countrymen – a change that carries within it a cause of profound tragedy. Our direct contact with the larger world of men was linked up with the contemporary history of the English people whom we came to know in those earlier days. It was mainly through their mighty literature that we formed our ideas with regard to these newcomers to our Indian shores. In those days the type of learning that was served out to us was neither plentiful nor diverse, nor was the spirit of scientific enquiry very much in evidence. Thus, their scope being strictly limited, the educated of those days had recourse to English language and literature. Their days and nights were eloquent with the stately declamations of Burke, with Macaulay's long-rolling sentences; discussions centered upon Shakespeare's drama and Byron's poetry and above all upon the large-hearted liberalism of the nineteenth-century English politics. At the time though tentative attempts were being made to gain our national independence, at heart we had not lost faith in the generosity of the English race. This belief was so firmly rooted in the sentiments of our leaders as to lead them to hope that the victor would of his own grace pave the path of freedom for the vanquished. This belief was based upon the fact that England at the time provided a shelter to all those who had to flee from persecution in their own country. Political martyrs who had suffered for the honour of their people were accorded unreserved welcome at the hands of the English. I was impressed by this evidence of liberal humanity in the character of the English and thus I was led to set them on the pedestal of my highest respect. This generosity in their national character had not yet been vitiated by imperialist pride. About this time, as a boy in England, I had the opportunity of listening to the speeches of John Bright, both in and outside Parliament. The large-hearted, radical liberalism of those speeches, overflowing all narrow national bonds, had made so deep an impression on my mind that something of it lingers even today, even in these days of graceless disillusionment.

Q1. From the first paragraph, give a synonym for 'deep':
a. Perspective
b. Profound
c. Tragedy
d. Psychology

Q2. What helped the Indians to conceive of a notion of the Englishmen?
a. Their advanced weaponry
b. Their literature
c. Their orders
d. Their administration

Q3. Who could read and gain from English literature?
a. The educated Indians
b. All the Indians

c. Only writers such as Rabindranath Tagore
d. None of the above

Q4. From the passage above, give an antonym for ‘victorious’.
a. Victor
b. Vanquished
c. Belief
d. Persecution

Q5. Whose speeches did Tagore listen to, as a boy?
a. Shakespeare
b. Byron
c. John Bright
d. Macaulay

Passage 2

‘Artificial intelligence (AI), sometimes called machine intelligence, is intelligence demonstrated by machines, in contrast to the natural intelligence displayed by humans and other animals. In computer science AI research is defined as the study of "intelligent agents": any device that perceives its environment and takes actions that maximize its chance of successfully achieving its goals. Colloquially, the term "artificial intelligence" is applied when a machine mimics "cognitive" functions that humans associate with other human minds, such as "learning" and "problem solving". The scope of AI is disputed: as machines become increasingly capable, tasks considered as requiring "intelligence" are often removed from the definition, a phenomenon known as the AI effect, leading to the quip, "AI is whatever hasn't been done yet." For instance, optical character recognition is frequently excluded from "artificial intelligence", having become a routine technology. Capabilities generally classified as AI as of 2017 include successfully understanding human speech, competing at the highest level in strategic game systems (such as chess and go), autonomous cars, intelligent routing in content delivery network and military simulations. Artificial intelligence was founded as an academic discipline in 1956, and in the years since has experienced several waves of optimism, followed by disappointment and the loss of funding (known as an "AI winter"), followed by new approaches, success and renewed funding. For most of its history, AI research has been divided into subfields that often fail to communicate with each other. These sub-fields are based on technical considerations, such as particular goals (e.g. "robotics" or "machine learning"), the use of particular tools ("logic" or artificial neural networks), or deep philosophical differences. Subfields have also been based on social factors (particular institutions or the work of particular researchers). The traditional problems (or goals) of AI research include reasoning, knowledge representation, planning, learning, natural language processing, perception and the ability to move and manipulate objects. General intelligence is among the field's long-term goals. Approaches include statistical methods, computational intelligence, and traditional symbolic AI. Many tools are used in AI, including versions of search and mathematical optimization, artificial neural networks, and methods based on statistics, probability and economics. The AI field draws upon computer science, mathematics, psychology, linguistics, philosophy and many others.

Q1. What is the AI winter?
a. Loss of funding for AI projects
b. Non-functioning AI systems
c. Absence of research labs
d. None of the above

Q2. Are sub-fields based only on social factors?

a. No
b. Yes
c. They are based on machine learning
d. None of the above

Q3. Leaning and problem solving by machines is a colloquial way of understanding artificial intelligence?

a. Yes
b. No
c. Artificial intelligence means acquiring knowledge through books
d. It cannot be defined colloquially

Q4. Are autonomous cars an example of AI?

a. Yes
b. No
c. As of 2017, they are
d. None of the above

Q5. Does AI only draw on technology and mathematics?

a. Yes
b. No
c. It also draws upon psychology
d. It only draws upon linguistics

Passage 3

“Like their ancient toga-wearing counterparts, modern philosophers continue to disagree on the nature of freewill. Do we really have any control over the choices we make and the things we desire, and if so, to what degree? Theories of freewill vary, but the ancient words of Plato still line up with our modern perceptions of temptation and willpower. The revered Greek philosopher argued that the human experience is one of constant struggle between the intellect and the body, between rationality and desire. Along these lines, true freedom is only achievable when willpower unchains us from bodily, emotional, instinctual slavery.

You can find similar sentiments throughout world religions, most of which offer a particular and often difficult path to rise above our darker natures. And science? Well, science mostly agrees with all of this. Willpower is all about overcoming your natural impulses to eat cupcakes, skip your morning workout, flirt with the waiter, hit the snooze alarm and check your e-mail
during a funeral.

Your willpower, however, is limited. If life were a video game, you'd see a glowing "willpower" or "ego" meter at the top of the screen next to your "life" meter. Successfully resist one temptation, and the meter depletes a little. The next temptation depletes the "willpower" meter even more, until there's nothing left at all.

Our modern scientific understanding of willpower in large part stems from a 1996 research experiment involving chocolate and radishes. Psychologist Roy Baumeister led a study in which 67 test subjects were presented with tempting chocolate chip cookies and other chocolate-flavored treats before a persistence-testing puzzle. Here's the catch: The researchers asked some of the participants to abstain from sweets and snack on radishes instead.

Baumeister's results told a fascinating story. The test subjects who resisted the sweet stuff in favor of radishes performed poorly on the persistence test. They simply didn't have the willpower left to resist slacking off. The resulting paper, "Ego Depletion: Is the Active Self a Limited Resource?" inspired more than a thousand additional studies discussing everything from the influence of positive messages to the ego-sapping power of daily decisions.

Studies also show that cognitive capacity also affects our ability to hold out against temptation. Cognitive capacity is essentially your working memory, which you employ when resisting a temptation ... or holding a string of numbers in your head. A 1999 study from the University of Iowa professor Baba Shiv found that people tasked with remembering a two-digit number held out better than people remembering a seven-digit number when tempted with chocolate cake.

Q1. What do you understand by 'freewill'?
a. The choices we make and the things we desire
b. The choices that philosophers force us to make
c. Our perception of temptation
d. Our ego

Q2. According to Plato, when is true freedom available?
a. When there is a struggle between the intellect and the body
b. When our willpower helps us to overcome our base instincts
c. When we desire that which we cannot achieve
d. When we have no control over our ego

Q3. In the second paragraph, what does the expression 'line up' signify?
a. Align with
b. Disagree with
c. Differ from
d. In discussion with

Q4. What is meant by 'cognitive capacity'?
a. Willpower
b. Our ego
c. Our ability to overcome temptation
d. The desire to give in to temptation

Q5. From the RC given above, find a synonym for 'respected'
a. Cognitive
b. Temptation
c. Desire
d. Revered

Passage 4

'**Algorithms, Intelligence, and the Question of Understanding**'

In recent decades, computer science has moved beyond its original focus on calculation and data processing to engage with questions that were once considered the exclusive domain of philosophy. At the center of this convergence lies a fundamental issue: can machines truly understand, or do they merely simulate understanding? This question has gained urgency with the rapid development of artificial intelligence (AI),

particularly systems capable of learning, generating language, and making decisions that resemble human reasoning.

An algorithm, in its simplest definition, is a finite set of well-defined instructions for solving a problem. Traditional algorithms operate deterministically: given the same input, they always produce the same output. Early computer programs reflected this structure closely, performing tasks such as sorting numbers or executing mathematical operations. These systems were powerful but limited; they did not adapt, interpret context, or deal well with ambiguity. Philosophically, they posed little challenge to human uniqueness, as they were clearly tools rather than thinkers.

The emergence of machine learning altered this perception. Instead of explicitly programming every rule, engineers began designing systems that could infer patterns from data. Neural networks, inspired loosely by the structure of the human brain, adjust their internal parameters through exposure to large datasets. As a result, modern AI systems can recognize faces, translate languages, and even compose essays or music. To many observers, such capabilities suggest a form of intelligence that approaches, or at least imitates, human cognition.

However, imitation raises an important philosophical concern. In 1980, philosopher John Searle proposed the famous "Chinese Room" thought experiment to argue that syntactic manipulation of symbols does not constitute genuine understanding. In this scenario, a person who does not understand Chinese follows a rulebook to manipulate Chinese symbols in such a way that native speakers outside the room believe they are communicating with a fluent speaker. According to Searle, although the system appears to understand Chinese, no real understanding is present—only symbol processing. By analogy, a computer may produce intelligent-seeming responses without any awareness or comprehension.

Supporters of strong AI challenge this conclusion. They argue that understanding need not involve consciousness or subjective experience. From this perspective, intelligence is defined functionally: if a system behaves as though it understands, then it effectively does. This view aligns with functionalism, a philosophical theory suggesting that mental states are defined by their roles and relations rather than by their internal composition. Just as a calculator "knows" how to add in a functional sense, an AI system may be said to understand language if it uses language appropriately.

Yet critics note that such functional definitions may overlook important qualitative aspects of human thought. Humans do not merely process information; they experience meaning, intention, and emotion. These elements are difficult to formalize computationally. Even advanced AI models rely on statistical correlations rather than semantic insight. When a language model predicts the next word in a sentence, it does so based on probabilities derived from vast datasets, not because it grasps the meaning of the sentence in the way a human does.

This distinction has practical as well as philosophical implications. As AI systems are increasingly deployed in areas such as law, medicine, and education, questions arise about responsibility and trust. If an AI system makes an error, who is accountable—the programmer, the user, or the system itself? Moreover, can we rely on decisions made by entities that lack understanding in the human sense? These concerns suggest that the debate is not merely theoretical but deeply connected to ethical and social considerations.

Some philosophers and computer scientists propose a middle position. They suggest that while machines may not possess understanding identical to human consciousness, they may develop forms of "machine understanding" that are different but still meaningful. Just as animal cognition differs from human cognition, artificial cognition may represent a new category altogether. This perspective encourages a reexamination of long-held assumptions about intelligence, mind, and the boundary between humans and machines.

Ultimately, the interaction between computer science and philosophy reveals that technological progress often revives ancient questions in new forms. Whether or not machines can truly understand may depend less on technological capability than on how we choose to define understanding itself. As algorithms continue to grow in complexity and influence, the need for philosophical reflection becomes not a luxury, but a necessity.

Q1. What is the primary purpose of the passage?
a. To examine whether artificial intelligence can genuinely understand
b. To compare early algorithms with modern hardware architectures
c. To explain how neural networks are programmed in modern computer systems
d. To argue that philosophy is irrelevant to computer science

Q2. According to the passage, how do traditional algorithms differ from modern machine learning systems?
a. Traditional algorithms rely on probability, while machine learning does not
b. Traditional algorithms are adaptive, whereas machine learning systems are fixed
c. Traditional algorithms follow explicit rules, while machine learning infers patterns from data
d. Traditional algorithms are philosophical in nature, while machine learning is purely technical

Q3. What does the "Chinese Room" thought experiment attempt to demonstrate?
a. That learning languages requires human-like consciousness
b. That symbol of manipulation alone does not guarantee understanding
c. That computers can never appear intelligent
d. That neural networks are superior to rule-based systems

Q4. Why does the author suggest that the debate about AI understanding has practical importance?
a. Because AI systems are becoming cheaper to produce
b. Because philosophical debates influence academic funding
c. Because AI is increasingly used in fields involving ethical responsibility
d. Because most users misunderstand how algorithms work

Q5. Which viewpoint is presented as a "middle position" in the passage?
a. Machines will eventually develop human-like consciousness
b. Machines are entirely incapable of any form of understanding
c. Functionalism fully explains all aspects of intelligence
d. Machine understanding may exist but differ fundamentally from human understanding

Passage 5

'Memory, Identity, and the Construction of the Self'

Human memory has long been a central topic in psychology, not only because it enables learning and problem-solving, but also because it plays a crucial role in shaping personal identity. Our sense of who we are—our beliefs, values, and life narratives—depends heavily on what we remember and how we remember it. Yet psychological research has shown that memory is neither a perfect recording of the past nor a passive storage system. Instead, it is an active, reconstructive process, influenced by emotion, context, and social interaction.
Early psychological theories treated memory as a relatively stable mental archive. Influenced by metaphors drawn from technology, researchers once compared the mind to a filing cabinet or a video recorder, storing experiences exactly as they occurred. However, experimental studies in the twentieth century began to challenge this assumption. Psychologists discovered that recall is often inaccurate and that memories can

change over time. Rather than retrieving a fixed record, individuals reconstruct memories each time they recall them, sometimes altering details without being aware of the change.

One influential figure in this shift was Frederic Bartlett, who demonstrated that people tend to reshape memories to fit existing mental frameworks, known as schemas. In his famous experiments, participants were asked to recall unfamiliar stories. Over repeated retellings, the stories became shorter, more coherent, and more consistent with the participants' cultural expectations. This suggested that memory is guided by meaning rather than accuracy. From a psychological perspective, this is not necessarily a flaw; schemas help individuals make sense of complex information efficiently. However, they also introduce systematic distortions.

Emotion further complicates the functioning of memory. Highly emotional events—such as accidents, personal achievements, or traumatic experiences—are often remembered more vividly than neutral ones. This phenomenon has led to the concept of "flashbulb memories," which are detailed recollections of significant events. While people tend to be highly confident in such memories, research indicates that confidence does not guarantee accuracy. Over time, even emotionally intense memories can become distorted, influenced by later experiences or repeated discussion.

The malleability of memory has important implications for personal identity. Many psychologists argue that identity is constructed through autobiographical memory: the stories individuals tell about their lives. These narratives provide continuity, linking past experiences to present goals and future plans. However, if memories are subject to change, then identity itself may be more flexible than commonly assumed. Changes in memory—whether due to aging, trauma, or reinterpretation—can alter how individuals perceive themselves and their past decisions.

This insight has been particularly relevant in clinical psychology. Therapeutic approaches such as cognitive-behavioral therapy (CBT) often involve helping individuals reinterpret past experiences in less harmful ways. Rather than attempting to recover an objective truth, therapists may focus on reshaping the meaning attached to memories. From this perspective, psychological well-being depends not on perfectly accurate recall, but on adaptive interpretation. Critics, however, warn that this approach raises ethical questions, especially when therapy influences memories of real events.

Memory's unreliability also has consequences beyond the individual. In legal psychology, eyewitness testimony has been shown to be vulnerable to suggestion. Leading questions, social pressure, and repeated interviews can all alter a witness's recollection. Numerous studies have demonstrated that people can come to remember events that never occurred, a phenomenon known as false memory. These findings have prompted reforms in police interviewing techniques and have led courts to treat eyewitness evidence with greater caution.

Despite these limitations, memory remains indispensable. Without it, learning would be impossible and personal continuity would collapse. Psychologists therefore emphasize the adaptive nature of memory rather than its imperfections. A reconstructive system allows individuals to integrate new information, draw meaningful connections, and plan for the future. In this sense, memory is less concerned with preserving the past than with serving present and future needs.

In recent years, advances in neuroscience have further enriched psychological theories of memory. Brain imaging studies suggest that remembering involves networks distributed across multiple brain regions, many of which are also involved in imagination and decision-making. This overlap supports the idea that memory is not solely about retrieval, but about mental simulation. Remembering the past and imagining the future may rely on similar cognitive processes, reinforcing the view that memory is a dynamic, constructive function of the mind.

Ultimately, psychological research challenges the common belief that memory provides a direct window into the past. Instead, it reveals memory as a complex, flexible process shaped by cognitive structures, emotions, and social contexts. While this may undermine confidence in memory as a reliable record, it also highlights its role in helping individuals make sense of their experiences. In psychology, understanding memory therefore means understanding not only how we remember, but why we remember the way we do.

Q1. What is the main idea of the passage?

a. Memory functions primarily as a biological storage system
b. Memory is an unreliable process that should not be trusted

c. Memory is a reconstructive process that influences identity and behavior
d. Memory accuracy has improved due to advances in neuroscience

2. According to Bartlett's research, why do memories often change over time?
a. Because people intentionally modify them
b. Because emotional events erase earlier details
c. Because memories are adjusted to fit existing schemas
d. Because repeated recall weakens memory traces

3. What does the passage suggest about "flashbulb memories"?
a. They are always more accurate than ordinary memories
b. They feel vivid and confident but may still be inaccurate
c. They disappear faster than neutral memories
d. They only occur during traumatic experiences

4. Why is memory malleability important in clinical psychology?
a. It enables reinterpretation of past experiences for well-being
b. It explains why therapy always changes personal identity
c. It allows therapists to recover forgotten childhood events
d. It proves that objective truth is irrelevant in therapy

5. Why does the author mention eyewitness testimony in legal contexts?
a. To illustrate the social consequences of unreliable memory
b. To argue that courts rely too heavily on psychology
c. To show that memory errors are rare but serious
d. To demonstrate that false memories are easy to detect